Western Embers Event Design

Arknights Event and Level Design

1 Event Overview

Event Name	Western Embers
Timeline	Immediately after Come Catastrophes or Wakes of Vultures
Main Characters	Jessica, the townspeople traveling with her, and western frontier pioneers
Core Themes	Western expansion / Gold rush and competition for resources / Corporate exploitation
Stage Count	8 main stages + 8 EX stages, all with Challenge Mode, plus 2 INST tutorials
Stage Order	INST-1 → 1 → 2 → INST-2 → 3 → 4 → 5 → 6 → 7 → 8 → EX-1 through EX-8
Mechanic Introduction Order	Introduce Supply Points and Pack Beasts first, followed by Originium Deposits, Minecarts, and Rails
Boss	Silas the Lasso, leader of the western frontier pioneers

The event takes place on Columbia's western frontier. After leaving Blacksteel Worldwide and her family, Jessica continues west with the townspeople. Originium veins attract pioneers, the Infected, bankrupt migrants, and immigrants from other countries. These groups clash over living space, resources, and identity. As the story progresses, conflict between communities gives way to a struggle over resources between the pioneers and large corporations.

2 Story

2.1 Heading West and Establishing the Setting

After Come Catastrophes or Wakes of Vultures, Jessica leaves Blacksteel Worldwide and her family and travels farther into western Columbia with the townspeople.

Descendants of Columbia's frontier settlers continue pushing westward and deeper underground in search of new Originium deposits.

Some Infected people, expelled because they cannot afford insurance premiums, join bankrupt migrants on the frontier. Pioneers from other countries are also drawn by the prospect of wealth and status.

Early tensions appear as conflicts between cultures, identities, and interest groups within frontier communities. Large corporations have long manipulated the divisions behind these conflicts.

2.2 Community Conflict and Reconciliation

Early in the story, Jessica's townspeople clash with local pioneer communities. The Infected face both discrimination and exploitation as cheap labor, becoming some of the conflict's main victims.

Through repeated negotiations and shared experiences, relations between the townspeople and some pioneers gradually improve. Jessica begins to understand the conditions in which local pioneers survive.

2.3 Manipulation Behind the Scenes

Large corporations remain hidden behind the conflict, amplifying divisions by spreading rumors, turning locals against newcomers, and offering rewards that encourage competition for resources.

They control the distribution of Supply Points, Pack Beasts, Minecarts, and other resources, forcing pioneer groups to compete. Long-term dependence leads the poorest pioneers to view these corporations as their saviors.

As Jessica investigates, she recognizes the same unseen influence behind the groups' disputes. Resources steadily flow into corporate hands during the conflict.

2.4 Collective Resistance and the Boss Conflict

Jessica, the townspeople, and pioneers willing to change gradually form a common front against corporate control of the frontier's resources and social order.

The pioneer leader Silas the Lasso refuses Jessica's proposed changes and holds to his original position, eventually confronting her group directly.

After the boss fight, Silas acknowledges that Jessica was right. He stops opposing the townspeople and resistance and joins them against the corporations.

The victory does not immediately restructure resource ownership on the frontier. It secures only limited improvements in corporate treatment of local people. However, groups that once regarded one another as enemies begin to stand together.

3 Stage Mechanics

3.1 Supply Points and Empowerment

An enemy or Pack Beast gains 1 Empowerment stack after spending 0.25 seconds on a Supply Point tile.

If a unit remains on a Supply Point and consumes its Empowerment, it regains the buff after 0.25 seconds.

There is only one type of Empowerment. Stacks enable different enemies' empowered basic attacks or special behaviors.

Pack Beasts receive approximately 80% damage reduction on Supply Points and can carry up to 3 Empowerment stacks. Additional stacks are ignored.

When an enemy mounts a Pack Beast, its original route remains unchanged, its movement speed and HP increase, and it can use all empowered attacks stored by the beast.

3.2 Originium Deposits

Each Originium Deposit has independent allied and enemy SP gauges. Neither gauge overflows when full, and each empties after its own effect activates.

Allied SP regenerates naturally at 1 per second, up to 40. At 40 SP, the player may spend DP to activate the skill and release its buffs, clearing the gauge.

Enemy SP increases by 1 per normal hit on the deposit, or by 3 when the attack carries Empowerment, up to 15. At 15 SP, all Minecarts on the field activate and the gauge empties.

Deposits can provide all operators with SP recovery for a period of time. Operators passing through receive brief increases to DEF, HP, and ASPD.

The deposit cannot be attacked during the Minecart's operating cycle, from activation until the cart returns to its original endpoint.

3.3 Minecarts and Rails

Minecarts start at the rail endpoint near the red gate and initially travel toward the endpoint near the blue gate.

The only normal activation condition is the enemy SP gauge of an Originium Deposit reaching 15.

A cart follows fixed rails, waits 3 seconds at the opposite endpoint, then automatically returns in the reverse direction.

Operators cannot be deployed on rail tiles. Enemy units may walk on them normally.

A Minecart checks 5 tiles for passengers: its own rail tile and the four orthogonally adjacent tiles. If multiple eligible enemies are in range, the nearest boards first.

Each cart carries at most 3 enemies. When it is full, subsequent enemies ignore it and continue along their own routes.

Passengers disembark on the tile where the cart stops at an endpoint. Some enemies then follow new routes, marked separately in the corresponding stage route map.

Attack direction is evaluated relative to cart movement. If a cart moves right, a leftward attack is opposing, a rightward attack follows its movement, and an upward or downward attack is perpendicular. Apply the same logic to other travel directions.

Only opposing attacks increase the reversal counter. Attacks following the cart or perpendicular to it have no effect.

Travel between endpoints is one journey. Opposing hits do not decay over time during that journey. After 8 opposing hits, the cart immediately reverses direction. The counter resets whenever the cart reaches either endpoint.

4 Enemy Mechanics

4.1 Consuming Empowerment

An enemy consumes 1 Empowerment stack on its next basic attack.

Multiple stacks allow consecutive empowered basic attacks.

An enemy's own stacks combine with its mount's stacks. For example, 1 on the rider plus 3 on the beast provides 4 empowered attacks in total.

4.2 Riding Pack Beasts

An eligible enemy attempts to mount when it occupies the same tile as a Pack Beast.

If several enemies become eligible at nearly the same time, the first to qualify in the actual simulation frame mounts. If they qualify at exactly the same time, the higher-tier enemy takes priority.

Enemies do not leave their original routes to board beasts or carts, and do not stop to wait for transport.

Mounted units can be slowed but cannot be stunned.

When a Pack Beast dies, its rider drops onto that tile without taking additional damage.

On its first movement after passing a Supply Point, a Pack Beast charges the nearest operator still capable of blocking it. A hit stuns that operator for several seconds. The charge is single-target.

4.3 General Interaction Rules

An enemy actively uses a deposit interaction only when its specific rules explicitly say it attacks Originium Deposits. Enemies without that rule do not additionally drain allied SP.

Debuffs of the same type may stack.

Restarting a stage resets deposit SP, cart positions and directions, beast buffs, enemy buffs, boss state, and one-time triggers to their initial states.

INST tutorials use the full underlying rules. Every mechanic triggers as it does in normal stages.

5 Enemy Types

ID	Standard Enemy	Elite Version
1	Pioneer Hound	Pioneer Hound Leader
2	Wasteland Pack Beast	Wasteland Pack Beast Leader
3	Drunken Pioneer	Drunken Pioneer Leader
4	Pioneer Beastcaller	Pioneer Beastcaller Leader
5	Pioneer Knifefighter	Pioneer Knifefighter Leader
6	Pioneer Caster	Pioneer Caster Leader
7	Corporate Overseer	Corporate Overseer Leader
8	Pioneer Shieldguard	Pioneer Shieldguard Leader

5.1 Pioneer Hound

Single-target melee physical damage.

Cannot mount Pack Beasts or board Minecarts.

Empowerment increases the damage of its next attack.

5.2 Wasteland Pack Beast

Single-target melee physical damage.

Can replenish up to 3 Empowerment stacks at a Supply Point.

Cannot board Minecarts.

On its first movement after passing a Supply Point, it charges the nearest operator capable of blocking it and stuns them for several seconds.

5.3 Drunken Pioneer

Basic attack: strikes with a bottle for single-target melee physical damage.

Can mount Pack Beasts; cannot board Minecarts.

After mounting, accelerates gradually to maximum movement speed.

At high speed, it can leap the beast over the first blocking operator and land 1.5 tiles behind them, avoiding the block.

Can only be blocked by operators with at least 2 Block. Gains a buff that reduces the effectiveness of slows.

If an operator is one tile behind the first, it fires a short crossbow at both targets simultaneously for high physical damage. Otherwise, it continues charging at high speed and jumping over operators.

5.4 Pioneer Beastcaller

Basic attack: a bow, dealing single-target ranged physical damage.

Can mount Pack Beasts; cannot board Minecarts.

On gaining Empowerment, summons a Pack Beast at the farthest summoning Supply Point and immediately sends it forward. Its next attack also gains damage.

5.5 Pioneer Knifefighter

Basic attack: a knife, dealing single-target melee physical damage.

Can mount Pack Beasts and board Minecarts.

With Empowerment, its attack becomes a medium-range crossbow shot dealing high single-target physical damage.

5.6 Pioneer Caster

Basic attack: single-target ranged Arts damage.

With Empowerment, throws a bomb dealing area Arts damage. The bomb attaches to an operator and explodes after a delay.

Cannot mount Pack Beasts; can board Minecarts.

While on a Minecart with an empowered attack available, targets the nearest Originium Deposit. A hit removes some allied SP.

5.7 Corporate Overseer

High HP and damage.

Basic attack: a whip dealing single-target melee physical damage. Its extended reach can hit elevated tiles.

With Empowerment, the whip becomes a lasso that restrains up to 2 operators, reduces their ASPD, and stuns them for 2 seconds. The debuff lasts until the Overseer dies, and its attack damage becomes Arts damage.

Can mount Pack Beasts and board Minecarts.

On a Minecart, deals Arts damage to operators within the cart's passing range.

On a Pack Beast, gains attack range and can restrain up to 3 operators with the lasso.

5.8 Pioneer Shieldguard

Basic attack: single-target melee physical damage.

Can board Minecarts; cannot mount Pack Beasts.

With Empowerment, throws three axes at Originium Deposits or the 3 lowest-HP operators in range.

Prioritizes Originium Deposits. Hitting one substantially increases its enemy SP.

Immediately gains one empowered basic attack on disembarking from a Minecart.

6 Boss Description

Boss Silas the Lasso

Silas leads the western frontier pioneers. He initially opposes Jessica and the townspeople. As corporate manipulation is exposed, some pioneers choose resistance, while Silas holds to his position and ultimately becomes the boss. After the fight, he accepts Jessica's judgment and ends his opposition.

6.1 Basic Traits

Has both melee and ranged attacks, each able to hit elevated tiles.

Both attack types can be empowered.

Can hold at most 3 Empowerment stacks.

6.2 Stealing Empowerment

Periodically uses his lasso to steal Empowerment. Target priority: the nearest Pack Beast on a Supply Point, then the nearest unmounted Pack Beast, then the nearest Supply Point.

A successful theft immediately fills Silas to 3 stacks and clears the target's existing stacks.

If the targeted beast remains on a Supply Point, it regains Empowerment after 0.25 seconds under the normal Supply Point rule.

6.3 Attacking Originium Deposits

Attacks deposit tiles, reducing the ASPD of operators within range for a period of time.

6.4 Duel Mechanic

Periodically challenges the operator with the highest DP cost within a defined range.

Tied costs use this class priority: Guard → Sniper → Defender → Medic → Supporter → Caster → Specialist → Summon → Device → Vanguard.

During the duel, only the boss and selected operator can damage each other.

The selected operator's existing buffs are removed when the duel starts. They cannot receive external healing or buffs during the duel. The boss can still gain buffs through his own mechanics.

The duel ends immediately if the selected operator retreats or dies.

Each boss attack steals some of that operator's ATK.

6.5 Phase Two After Revival

Briefly becomes invulnerable after reviving.

The instant invulnerability ends, fires 6 empowered attacks, distributed as evenly as possible among up to 6 targets in range. If fewer than 6 targets exist, remaining attacks go to the nearest target. With 5 targets, for example, each takes 1 attack and the nearest takes an additional one.

Summons Pack Beasts at several Supply Points.

Gains ATK and ASPD, and steals Empowerment more frequently.

At 75% HP in phase two, the mount-fusion mechanic can trigger once per battle. If beasts are present, select the one nearest the boss. Equal distances are resolved in favor of the beast nearest the red gate.

During the mounting transition, the chosen beast gains temporary damage immunity to prevent it from being killed mid-trigger.

After mounting, Silas and the beast merge into one unit and the original beast entity disappears. It does not reappear when the boss dies.

Fusion grants increased ATK, HP, movement speed, and unlimited empowered basic attacks.

7 Core Mechanic Relationships

The following summarizes the main interactions among Supply Points, Pack Beasts, Originium Deposits, Minecarts, and the boss.

Mechanic Relationships

Supply Points grant 1 Empowerment stack after 0.25 seconds and replenish it after consumption. Pack Beasts receive approximately 80% damage reduction there and hold at most 3 stacks.

Supply Points empower enemies and Pack Beasts. Eligible enemies mount beasts on the same tile, preserve their routes, and combine their own stacks with those carried by the beast. Enemies do not wait for transport.

Originium Deposits gain allied SP at 1 per second, up to 40 for skill activation. Enemy attacks add 1 SP, or 3 when empowered. Reaching 15 enemy SP activates every Minecart and clears the gauge. Deposits cannot be attacked while the carts operate.

Minecarts initially travel from the red-gate endpoint toward the blue-gate endpoint. Their five-tile boarding area admits at most 3 enemies. Eight opposing hits cause an immediate reversal; reaching an endpoint resets the counter.

Silas steals up to 3 Empowerment stacks, prioritizing beasts at Supply Points, then unmounted beasts, then Supply Points. He attacks Originium Deposits, summons beasts in phase two, and fuses with a beast once at 75% phase-two HP. His duel tests how the player manages these core resources.

Core cycle: Supply Points empower enemies and beasts → enemies charge Originium Deposits → Minecarts activate and alter enemy movement and subsequent routes → the boss combines these mechanics.

The original diagram's phase-two mounting arrow points toward Minecarts. The detailed boss rules specify a Pack Beast, and the interaction table says the boss cannot board Minecarts.

8 Enemy and Stage Mechanic Interactions

Standard enemies and their Leader versions share mechanics. Leaders only receive stat increases.

Enemy Interaction Matrix

Pioneer Hound: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast no; Minecart no; deposit attack no. Its next attack deals more damage.

Wasteland Pack Beast: Empowerment up to 3 stacks; mounting not applicable; Minecart no; deposit attack no. Gains Supply Point damage reduction and charges on its first movement afterward.

Drunken Pioneer: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast yes; Minecart no; deposit attack no. Accelerates while mounted and can leap past operators with insufficient Block.

Pioneer Beastcaller: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast yes; Minecart no; deposit attack no. Summons a beast at the farthest Supply Point when empowered.

Pioneer Knifefighter: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast yes; Minecart yes; deposit attack no. Its empowered attack becomes a high-damage medium-range crossbow shot.

Pioneer Caster: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast no; Minecart yes; deposit attack conditional. Attacks a deposit while riding a cart with an empowered attack ready.

Corporate Overseer: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast yes; Minecart yes; deposit attack no. Deals Arts damage around its cart; riding a beast increases lasso control range.

Pioneer Shieldguard: Empowerment yes; Pack Beast no; Minecart yes; deposit attack conditional. Empowered attacks prioritize deposits; disembarking grants an empowered basic attack.

Silas the Lasso: steals up to 3 stacks; conditional phase-two Pack Beast mounting; Minecart no; deposit attack yes. Mount fusion triggers once at 75% phase-two HP.

9 Map and Tile Legend

The table lists standard tile colors and symbols used in the maps. Refer to each stage's route map for route colors, branches, and special markers.

Type	Color	Description
Blue gate		Enemy spawn / Route start
Red gate		Enemy destination / Route end
Walkable deployable ground		Walkable; ground operators can be deployed

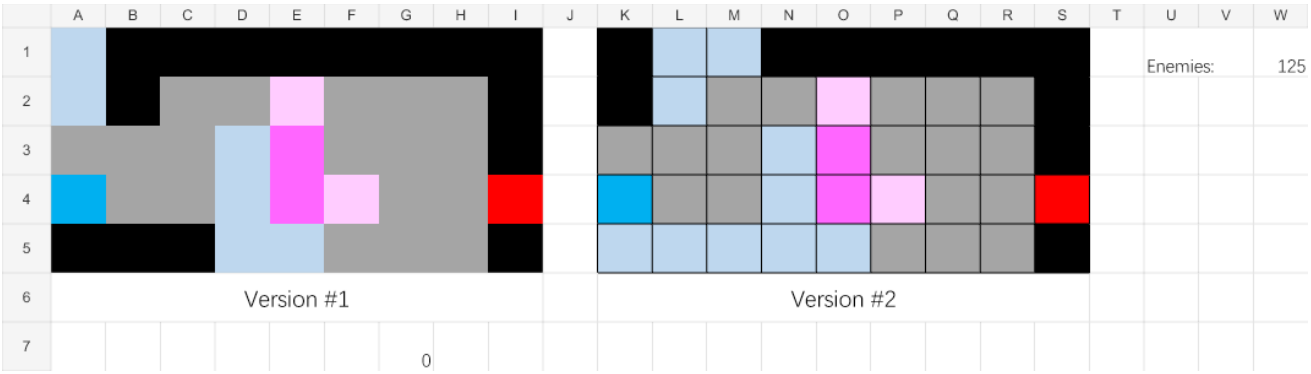
Type	Color	Description
Walkable non-deployable ground		Walkable; operators cannot be deployed
Elevated tile		Ranged operators can be deployed
Inaccessible non-deployable tile		Neither walkable nor deployable
Teleport tile		Arrows and matching colors indicate teleport connections
Originium Deposit tile		Tile for the Originium Deposit mechanic
Minecart / Rail tile		Tile for Minecart and Rail mechanics
Supply Point tile		Tile for the Supply Point mechanic
Supply Point scenery tile		Supporting scenery around Supply Points
Pit tile		Neither deployable nor walkable; enemies entering fall to their deaths

Enemy IDs: 1 Pioneer Hound; 2 Wasteland Pack Beast; 3 Drunken Pioneer; 4 Pioneer Beastcaller; 5 Pioneer Knifefighter; 6 Pioneer Caster; 7 Corporate Overseer; 8 Pioneer Shieldguard. The document uses the same base ID scheme for Leaders, adding Leader to their names.

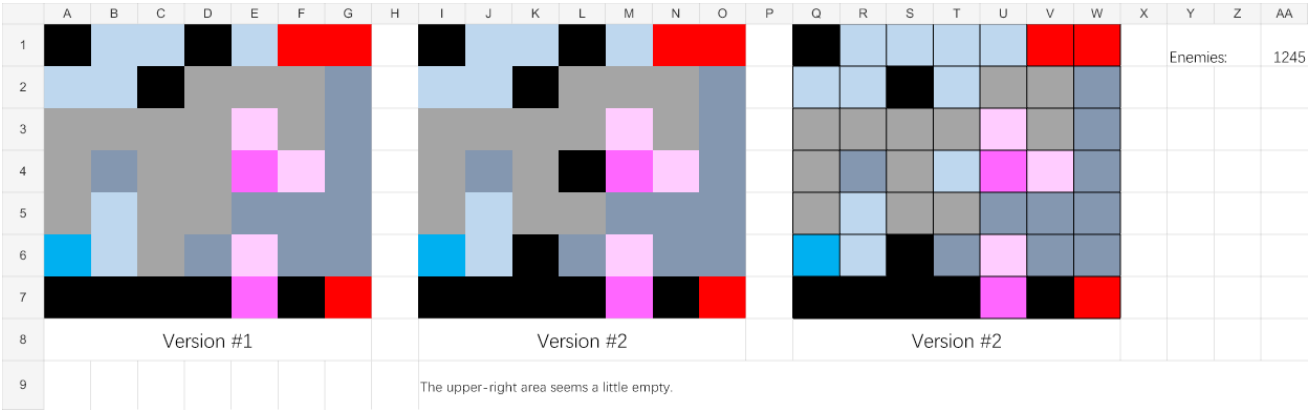
10 Stage Maps and Routes

The maps come from the level-design workbook and cover INST tutorials, main stages 1–8, and EX-1 through EX-8. Routes, tile colors, and mechanic symbols follow the legend above.

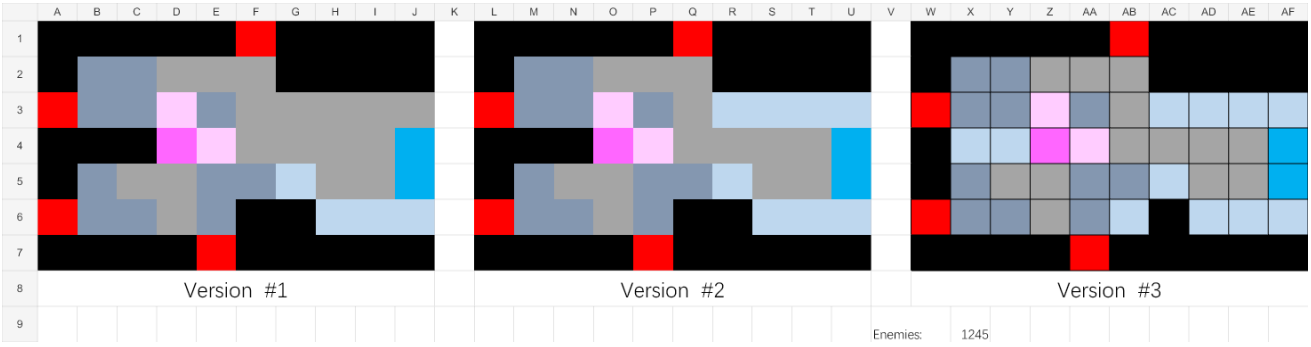
Stage INST-1



Stage 1



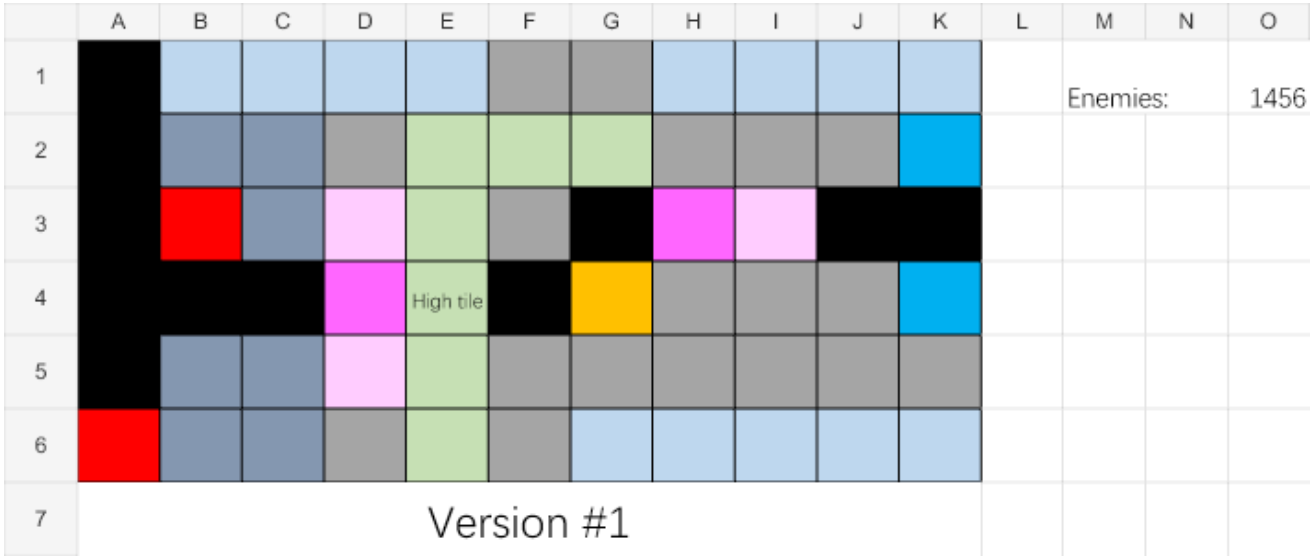
Stage 2



Stage INST-2



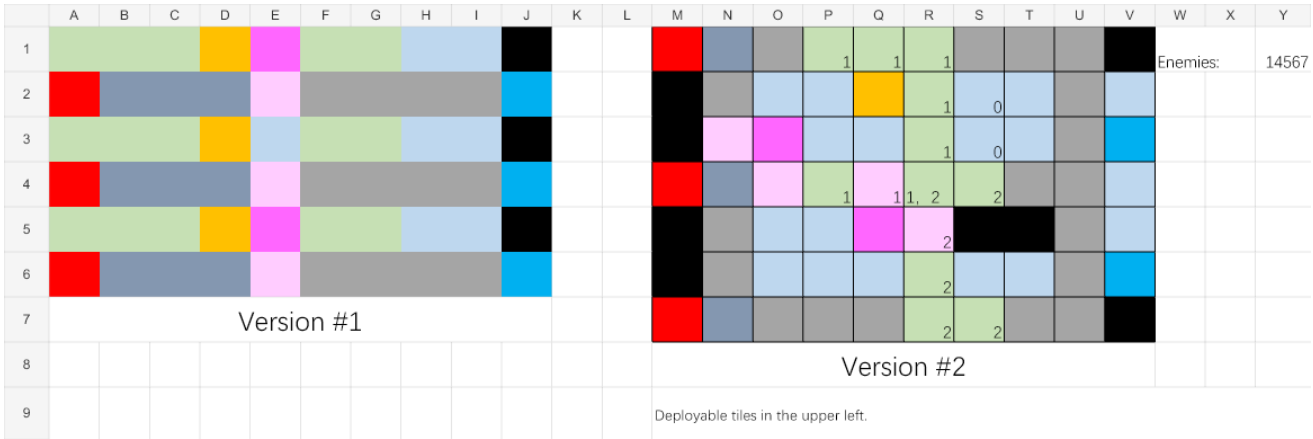
Stage 3



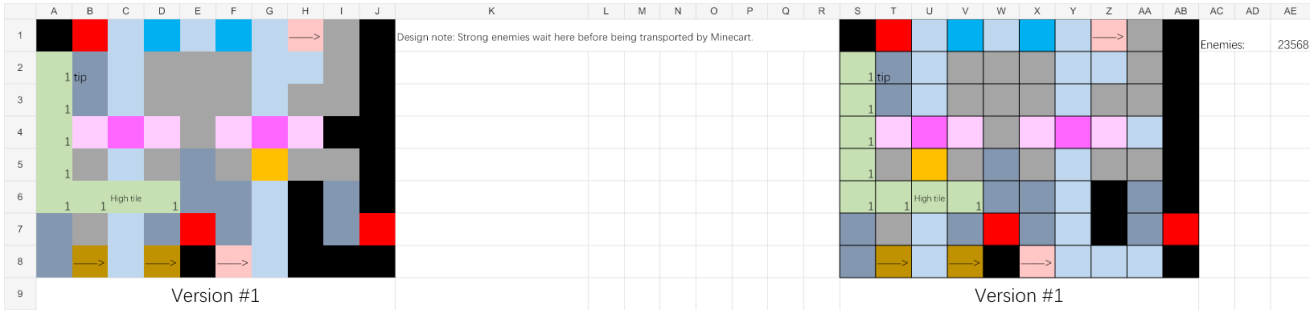
Stage 4



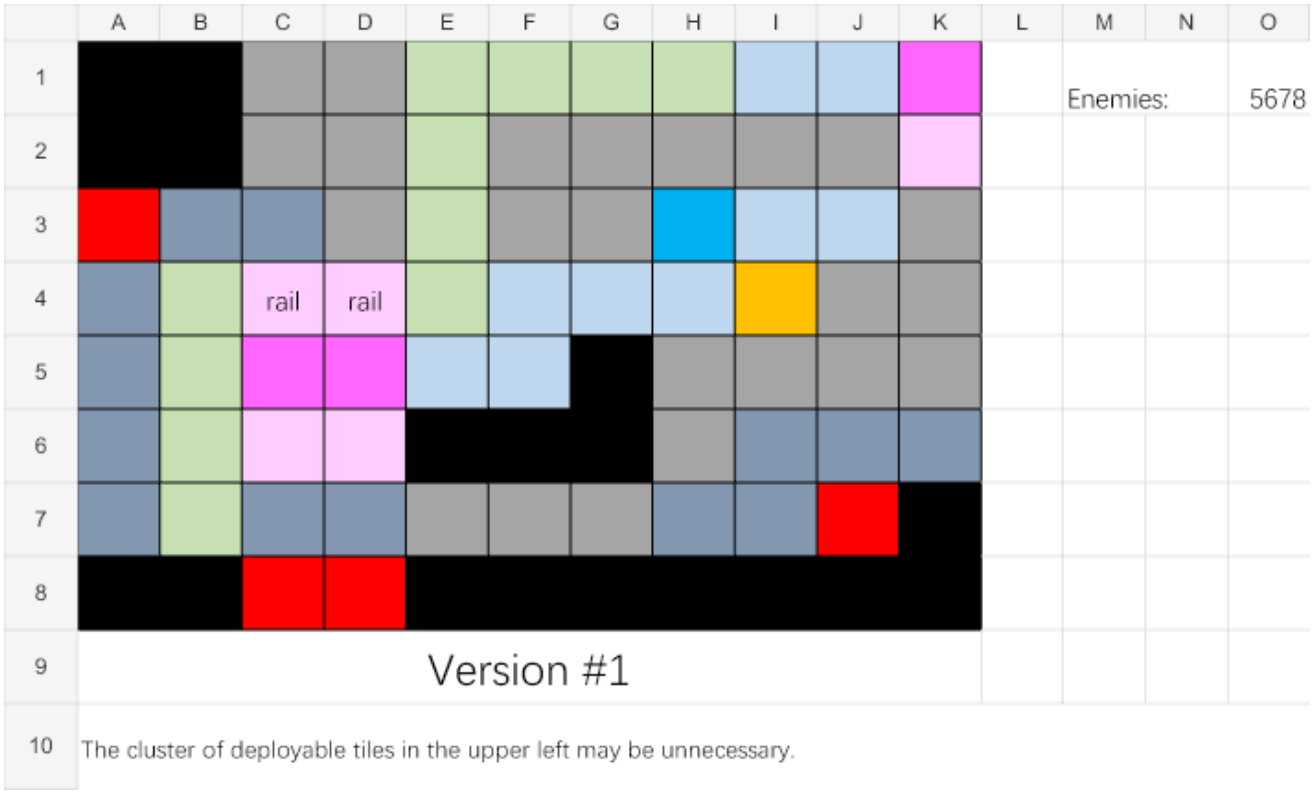
Stage 5



Stage 6



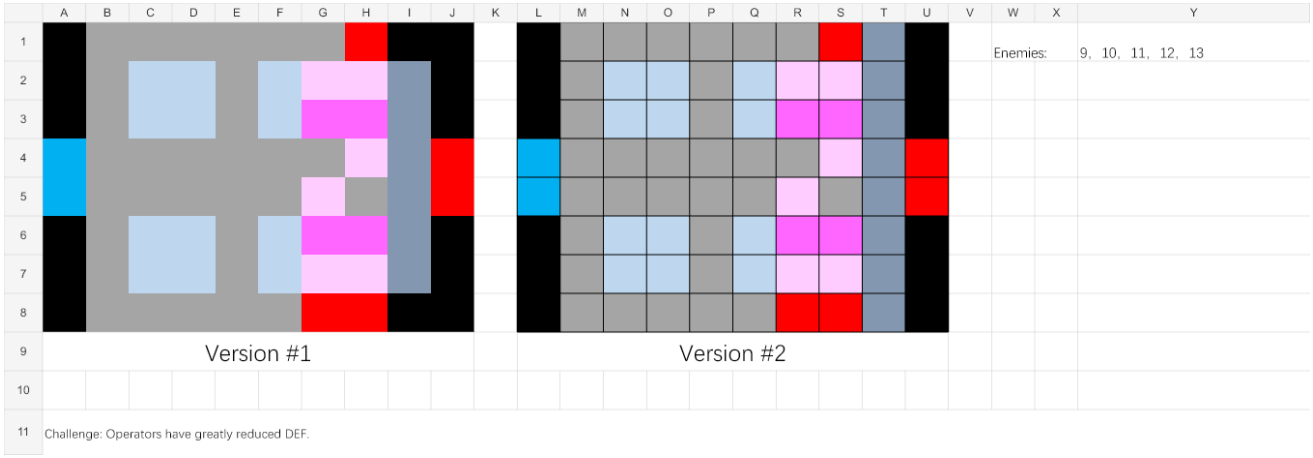
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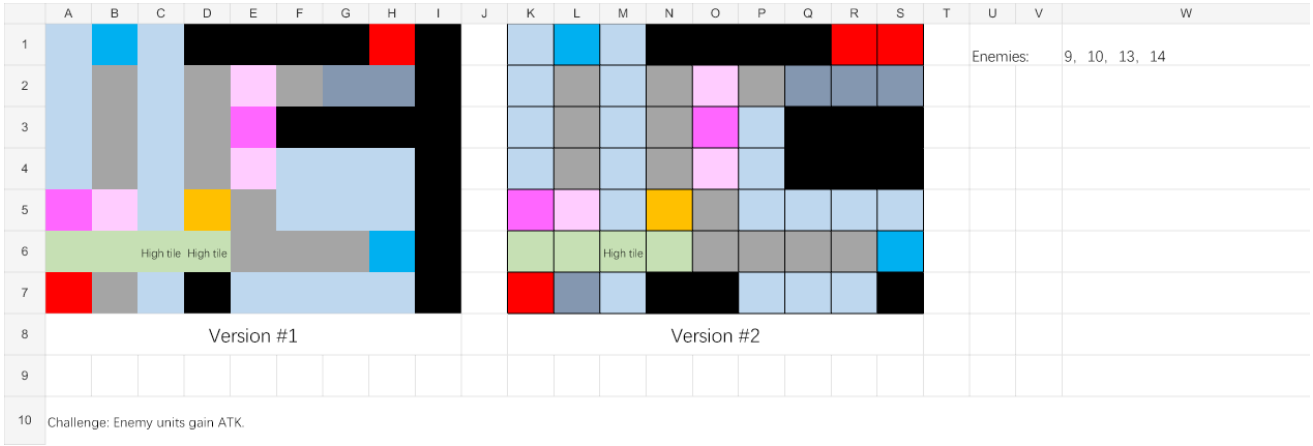
Stage 8



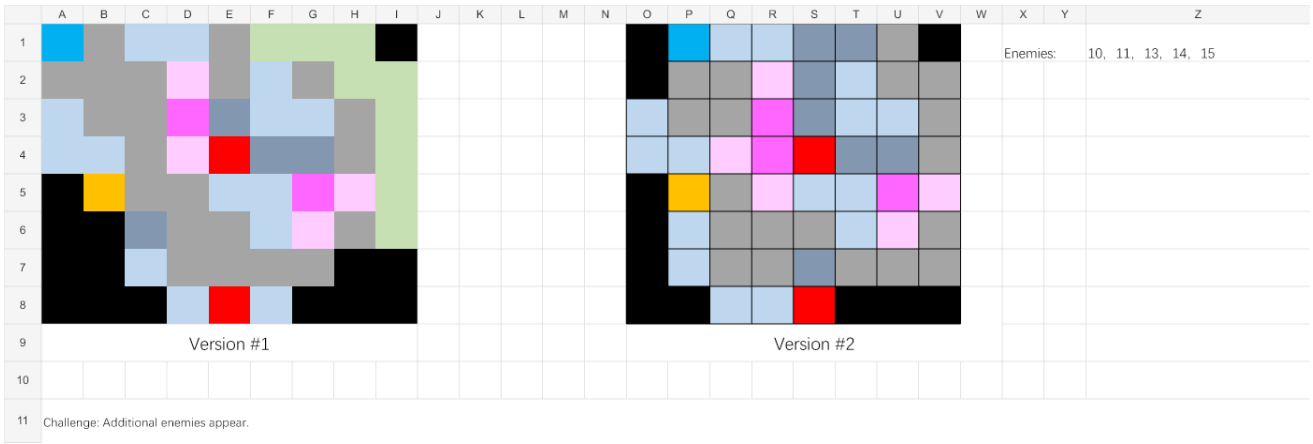
Stage EX-1



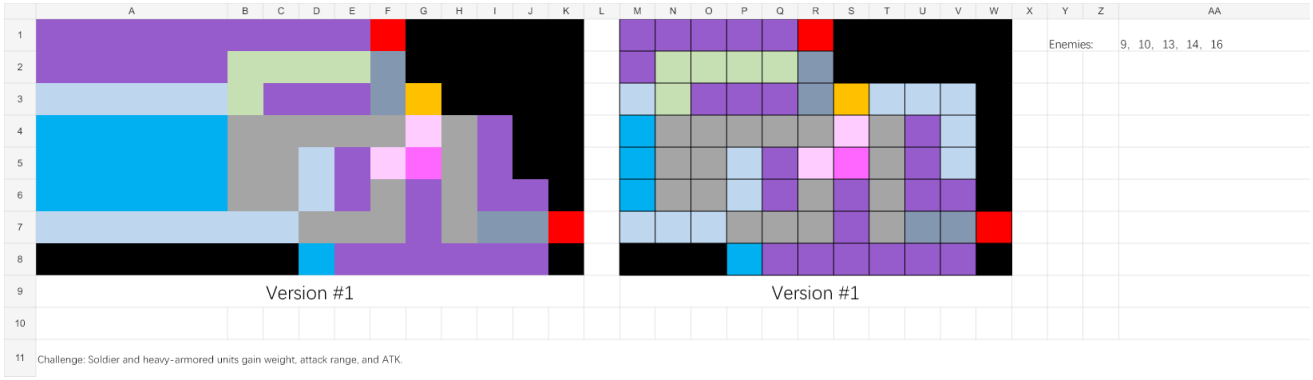
Stage EX-2



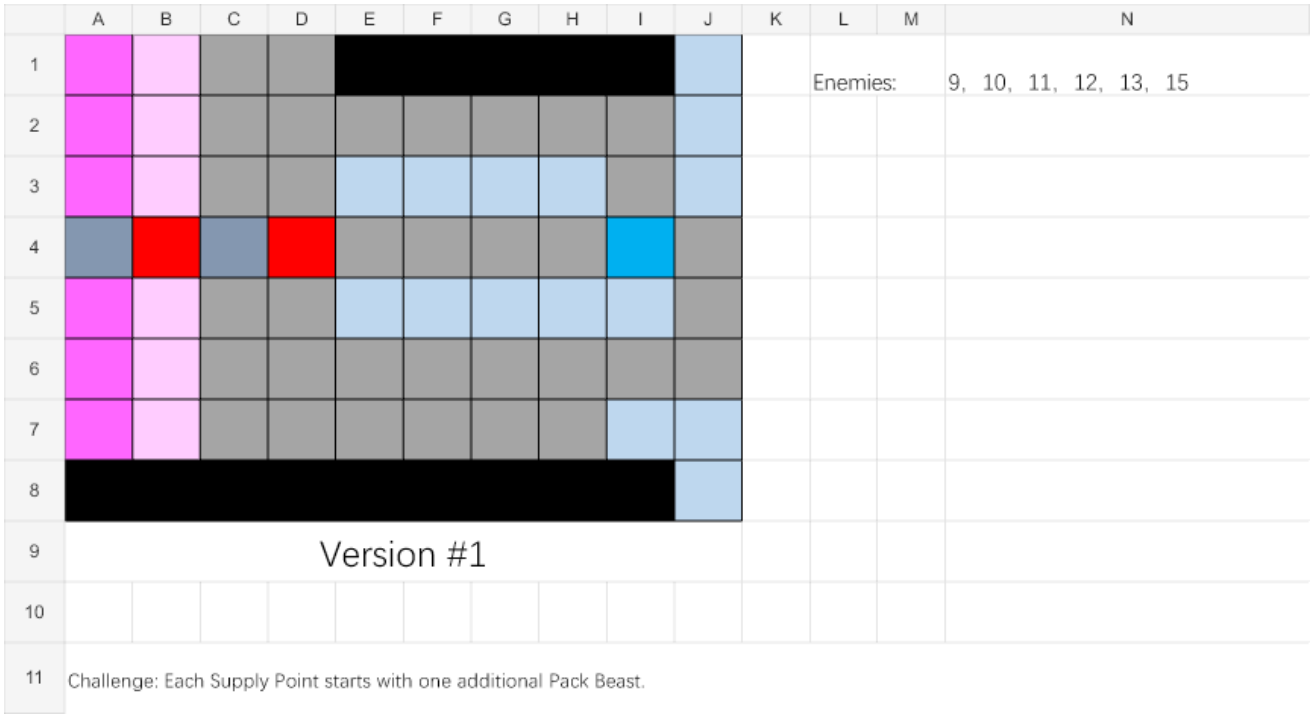
Stage EX-3



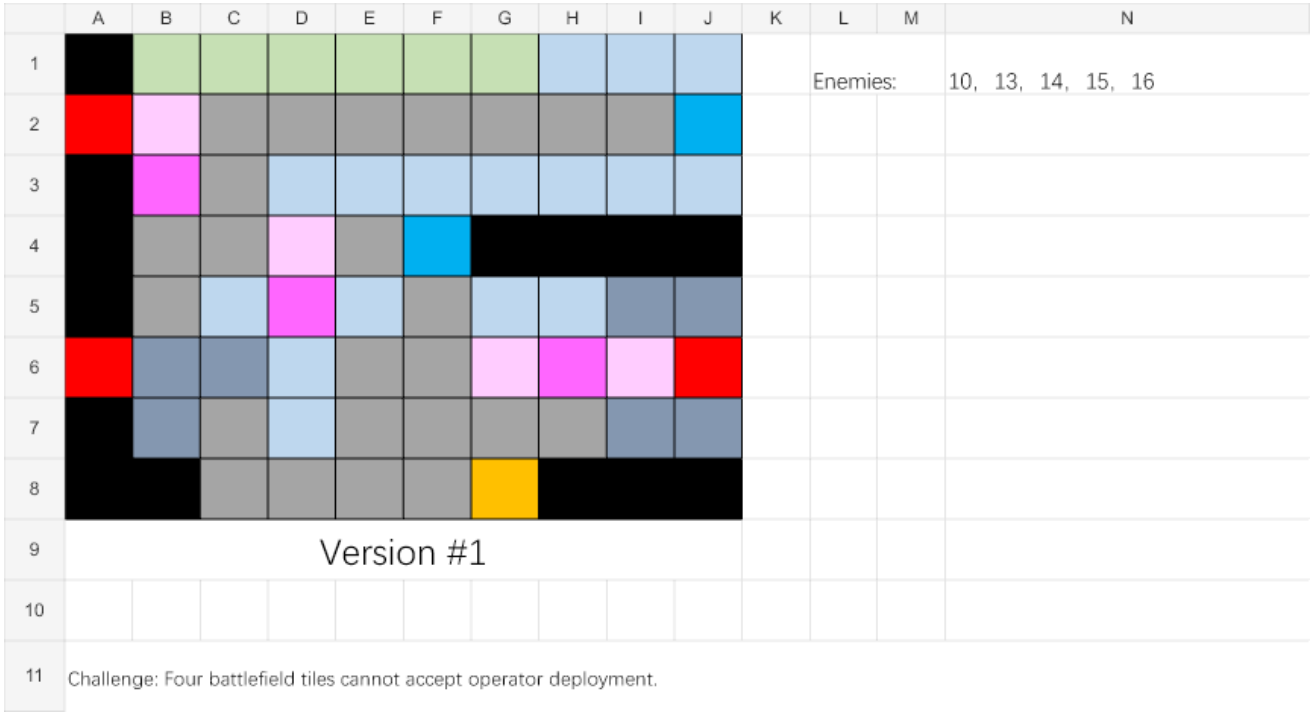
Stage EX-4



Stage EX-5

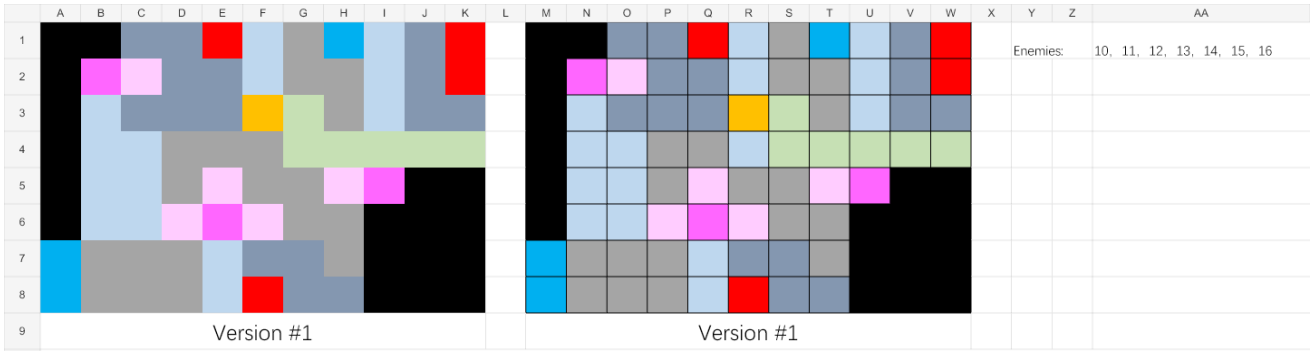


Stage EX-6



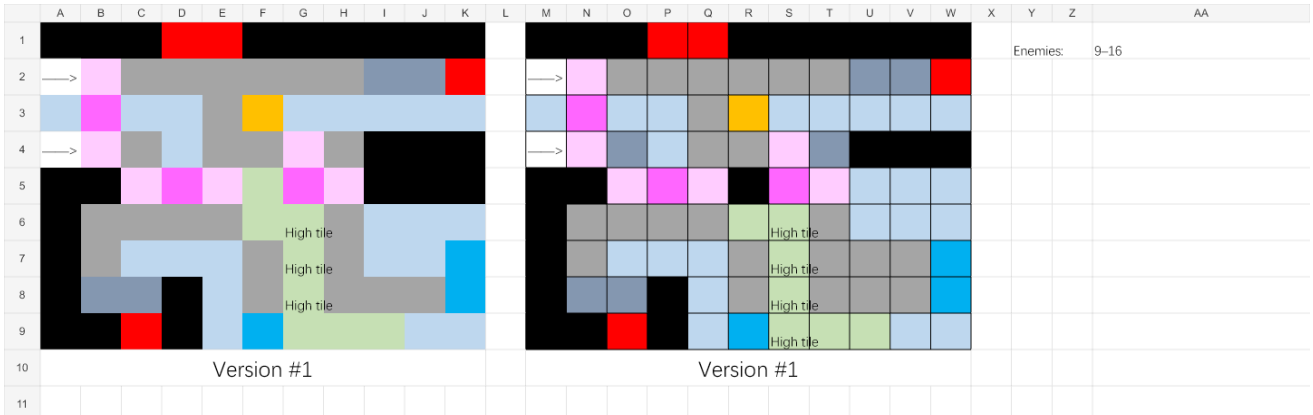
Challenge: Four battlefield tiles cannot accept operator deployment.

Stage EX-7



Challenge: All enemies gain movement speed.

Stage EX-8



Challenge: Bring no more than 10 operators.

11 Art and Visual Direction

The event's visuals draw on Columbia's desert frontier, combining imagery from the American West and gold-rush era with Arknights' Originium industry.

Environment keywords: desert, western frontier, mining districts, rails, wooden camps, makeshift supply stations, Originium veins, and industrial facilities.

Visual priority: make Supply Points, Originium Deposits, Minecarts, and Rails immediately recognizable. Mechanic tiles must remain readable while fitting the environment.

Narrative atmosphere: competition among pioneers gradually gives way to corporate control and collective resistance. Environments can progress from scattered camps, mines, and transport facilities toward areas with a more visible corporate presence.

References: American frontier expansion, the gold rush, and desert road-movie atmospheres. The overall tone is rough, dry, and utilitarian, avoiding excessive ornament.